of how they overcame extreme difficulties and of the unequalled achievement of our Soviet class-brothers.

While in Moscow, Honecker had two ‘in the flesh’ encounters with his hero Stalin – albeit from a distance: ‘It was the greatest thing I have ever experienced,’ he gushed.5 His first glimpse of ‘the great man’ occurred in January 1931 during the Congress of the Leninist Young Communist League at the Bolshoi Theatre, where he sat four rows behind the Russian dictator. Sometime later, he saw him again at a meeting of the Supreme Soviet in the Great Hall of the Kremlin. ‘The Moscow, which I left in the summer of 1931,’ Honecker later stated, ‘was already clearly another Moscow than when I arrived a year earlier. It had become familiar to me.’

On returning to Germany, Erich Honecker delivered accounts of his experiences at youth discussion evenings arranged by the KJVD. He rhapsodised about Magnitogorsk, Moscow, and Stalin’s ambitious five-year plans. His enthusiasm was quickly rewarded with the post of local secretary for agitation and political director of the Saar Young Communist League, for which he was paid a monthly salary of 250 francs. From here on, he was able to apply what he had learned in Moscow in a leading party function. ‘Honecker was a brilliant orator,’ according to Erich Voltmer, the late editor of the Saarbrücker Zeitung. ‘He avoided the rough and tumble of street clashes’ with political opponents, choosing instead to leave ‘that to his comrades, who regarded him as their unchallenged leader and spokesman – although most of them were a lot older than he was’.6 Honecker, Voltmer said, was a toughened and dedicated activist and wouldn’t recognise any opinion but his own. ‘And he got results, because in the November 1932, election nine Communists, five Social Democrats, five Democrats, three representatives of the Centre Party, and only two Nazis, were elected to the Wiebelskirchen town council.’

Although the National Socialists fared poorly, their leader, Adolf Hitler, campaigned by crisscrossing Germany by air, and managed to swell Party membership from 129,500 in September 1930, to 450,000 in mid-1932. Remarkably, during this threatening climate, communist propaganda largely